

After Action Review: Nepal Earthquake, April, May 2015



NEPAL: A man stands in the rubble of collapsed buildings after the first earthquake.

UNDP has conducted an After Action Review (AAR) of its response to the earthquakes that struck Nepal on 25 April and 12 May, 2015. More than 8,800 people were killed in the disaster, more than 605,000 homes destroyed and more than 288,000 homes damaged. At the time, UNDP had just established a Crisis Response Unit and implemented new corporate procedures to help ensure it responds quickly, predictably and effectively to crises. After the first Nepal earthquake, UNDP activated these new procedures and mobilized a whole-of-agency response to help meet the immediate needs of vulnerable people and kick-start early recovery at the same time. A key feature of UNDP's earthquake response was its support for the Government of Nepal in developing a quality Post-Disaster Needs Assessment.

UNDP conducted an AAR to help improve its crisis response processes and tools. The findings are informing the development of UNDP's crisis response 'packages', to support a fast, effective and predictable response to sudden-onset or complex crises. The review included feedback from national and regional stakeholders, and from UNDP headquarters in New York.

Strengths of Response

Corporate crisis response mechanism: The Crisis Board quickly mobilized and the Crisis Management Support Team helped to ensure the Board's decisions were implemented. Pre-briefings for SURGE experts were effective in ensuring they integrate well into the crisis context.

Programmatic response: UNDP successfully mobilized a whole-of-UNDP response and a substantial number of additional experts. This was crucial in supporting the Government in developing

a quality Post-Disaster Needs Assessment. UNDP also played a unique role in promoting innovation and private sector engagement during the disaster response, including by launching a debris management application through Microsoft support. This app helped response teams to monitor the volume of work required and track cash-for-work payments.

Interagency coordination: UNDP's internal processes were flexible, allowing the transfer of several people to support the Early Recovery Cluster.

Resource mobilization: UNDP immediately released startup funds and reprogrammed resources which helped to ensure its crisis response was effective. The inclusion of a communications specialist in the first responder team was important to ensure visibility for UNDP's important role supporting early recovery from the crisis.

Challenges and gaps

Corporate crisis response mechanism: The SURGE plan could have taken into account more analysis of interventions by other key actors, government priorities and the donor environment in Nepal, in addition to the needs of affected communities.

Programmatic response: A more careful analysis of the areas in which UNDP adds value and a clearer articulation of the ways in which its crisis response builds on its existing work with the Government and other partners could have been useful. It might have helped to define a strategy and strengthened the response.

Operational response: Although the Fast Track Procedure was quickly activated, the Country Office frequently had to revert to headquarters to approve the recruitment of extra staff. Further, there was a lack of understanding within the Country Office of how to implement those Fast Track Procedures. A high turnover of staff had undermined the office's preparedness.

In addition, various UN agencies provided different levels of assistance to their affected staff (tents, food, water, medicines etc.), which caused added tension. A standardized form of UN assistance would help to avoid this discrepancy in the future.

Inter-agency coordination: UNDP could have better 'firewalled' the early recovery cluster role from its own early recovery programme. Greater awareness amongst Country Office staff of cluster roles, responsibilities and lines of accountability would be helpful. UNDP could also have offered specialized expertise in areas such as inclusive financial infrastructure and market and local economy assessments. In addition it could have proposed an expansion of cash-based interventions.

Further, UNDP could have immediately started talking to development partners and governments about funding mechanisms for early recovery and reconstruction. UNDP could also have better supported the advocacy needed at IASC level to agree on a recovery transition mechanism.

Resource mobilization: Clear articulation of a medium- and long-term vision would have enabled UNDP to engage better with donors early on in the response. The deployment of senior communication staff capable of developing clear donor messages is crucial in this regard.

UNDP should also have finalized a clear offer to attract private sector funding. In fact UNDP did receive several offers from private sector companies interested in supporting the response.

Moving forward

UNDP is strengthening its leadership and management capacity for crisis response and investing more in Country Office preparedness and capacity, while it reviews Standard Operating Procedures and finalizes its crisis response packages. UNDP will continue to improve its role in crisis assessments, particularly in Post Disaster Needs Assessments and in programmes.

In the first 12 months of the earthquake response, UNDP mobilized almost 4,350 people to help clear debris under a cash-for-work programme. Four out of ten participants were women.

This not only helps the community to recover but helps vulnerable families to earn income and get back on their feet.



Photo: UNDP/Lesley Wright



FOR MORE
INFORMATION VISIT
WWW.UNDP.ORG

United Nations Development Programme
One United Nations
Plaza New York, NY,
10017 USA